

Nomenclature, for absolutely everything, is imperative. Imagine if local buses weren't numbered, or if books weren't given titles. Just as going to the destination of your choice, or picking the right book at a library would be a headache, it is likely that with thousands of media files on your computer, finding the right one would be *muchos* effort if it didn't have the right file name.

This chapter explains why you really don't want to listen to something by Boyzone when you clicked on what you thought was something by Metallica, and how to completely avoid this situation.

11.1 ID3 Tags

No, we're not talking about Tom Cruise's secret password in *Mission Impossible*. Essentially, an ID3 tag allows you to store information about the MP3 (ID3 is used only in relation to MP3 files) within the MP3 itself. It's like the library card of a book, except an ID3 tag doesn't leave your MP3 when you "check it out" of your computer.

Let's Get Technical

Metadata! That's what an ID3 tag is. Simply put, Metadata is information about information. Your standard MP3 file is basically a collection of zeros and ones, and its identity is defined by a unique arrangement of those numbers. What an ID3 tag does, as metadata, is add information about that file, to the file itself. This data is then accessed by your media player which reads it out as a song name, artist, album, etc.

Most media players display song information about MP3s on the basis of the information stored in ID3 tags. They also allow you to edit this information and add details such as lyrics, artwork, etc. to the MP3. But the amount and types of information that you can store in ID3 tags depends on what version of ID3 you are using. There are basically two versions of ID3 tags—ID3v1 and ID3v2—but both these are essentially unrelated.